Afghanistan (RECCA) and the Delhi Investment Summit in June 2012. The only India-Pakistan-Afghanistan trilateral was the Track-II arranged by the Delhi Policy Group.[156] Disconnected from the political and security dynamics on the ground, most such conferences were a series of failed promises. Translating into a collective decline of hope around the prospects for peace and stability in Afghanistan, persistent uncertainty pushed Afghanistan's neighbours into hedging their bets.

Unlike the late-1990s when Russia, Iran, and India coalesced into a strategic embrace against the Taliban, regional political equations were very different this time around. Not just Iran, even Moscow was no longer militantly opposed to the Taliban by 2014. Though Moscow shared India's concerns on reconciliation in 2010, as the NATO-Russia rivalry focused on Ukraine and Syria, the question of militarily containing the Afghan Taliban lost saliency in Russia.[157] The rise of ISIS in Afghanistan gave the Taliban and Russia a platform for tactical collaboration in fighting against a common enemy.[158] Building and sustaining such operational linkages with the Taliban required Moscow to develop ties with Pakistan. Not surprisingly, the two countries signed a landmark defence deal in August 2015 that allowed the sale of four Mi-35 'Hind-E' attack helicopters.[159] Russia's opening-up to Pakistan came in context of India's pro-US tilt. Not worried about militancy in Chechnya, Moscow's threat perception from Afghanistan in 2015 was different from that in 1996. Though India's lack of criticism during Russia 2014 annexation of Crimea helped alleviating differences, Russia had little appetite to form a 1990s-style similar Russia-Iran-India axis.[160]

If Russia and Iran's evolving postures gave the conciliators a fillip, China's political participation in Afghanistan by 2015 gave them a boost. China had been silently engaging with both Russia and India within the Russia-India-China (RIC) trilateral to enhance a multipolar world. In October 2007, foreign ministers of the three regional powers met in Harbin, China, and reached an agreement that they work together to counter the rise of the Taliban in Afghanistan (among other issues). While the Russians saw the meeting as 'pivotal',[161] the Chinese viewed it as a vehicle to emphasise multilateral diplomacy rather than getting substantive results.[162] To this effect, in 2006, Beijing had floated the idea of launching a China-US-India trilateral in order to discuss issues